

W(hy)i-Fi?

Wi-Fi, as the IEEE 802.11 wireless networking protocol family is commonly called, is certainly going places. Walk out of an airplane at the Delhi airport, whip open your laptop and get online. Stroll down the leisurely surroundings of Delhi's business class hotels, and stay connected. Pop in for a quick swim at Mumbai's hotels—still connected.

A coffee break isn't an excuse to go offline anymore—Bangalore's Java City range of coffee pubs, and many other popular hangout spots, are only too glad to offer you wireless Internet access. Chances are that your company

might be considering Wi-Fi too.

The need of a burgeoning laptop population to stay connected is making much of corporate India look at this wireless option.

Junk the wires, suits

Wi-Fi stands for Wireless Fidelity, and it's the promise of wireless access that makes it sound so attractive. Wi-Fi setups within a corporate environment make you truly mobile, and you don't have to connect a CAT5 cable to your laptop.

Ask Exel India Assistant General Manager, IT, Suresh Subramaniam, who wants to get the large laptop base within his company networked without wires over this year. Or talk to Anil Shankar, Team Leader, Information Systems, Shoppers' Stop, who is all excited about it. Pathways International School, Delhi, also has a Wi-Fi network running on campus. The hotspots at the Delhi and Chennai airports, and those at Bangalore's hangout joints and cyber cafés, are courtesy Sify. Suburban Mumbai's Le Royal Meridien (LRM) hotel also has a Wi-Fi network in place for its guests.

The advantages over wired LANs are obvious. Once the access points (APs) are

Laptop users have junked CAT5 cables. Airports, coffee bars and your company, are probably doing the same

ILLUSTRATION: Mahesh Benkar
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